

SSA Starter Worksheet

The first steps for a Social Security disability application (SSI or SSDI). The steps, the papers you need, and how long it takes — on a few pages. Check off each step as you go.

Southern Oak Financial & Wellness • southernoakfw.org

How to use this worksheet: Check each box as you finish it. Fill in the lines with your own information. Keep it with your important papers. Bring it to every appointment.

The Steps, At a Glance

Step 1 — Learn the programs. SSI is for people with low income and few resources. SSDI is based on your work history. Some adults can get DAC benefits on a parent's record. It helps to know which one fits you.

Step 2 — Gather your documents (checklist below).

Step 3 — Start the application at ssa.gov, by phone at 1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778), or at your local Social Security office. The day you start protects your filing date — do not wait until everything is perfect.

Step 4 — Complete the reports. Social Security will ask for a disability report, a function report, and a work history report. Be complete and honest: describe a hard day, not the best day.

Step 5 — Keep medical care going. Gaps in treatment can hurt a claim. Go to appointments and keep records updated.

Step 6 — Watch the mail and answer everything. Most problems start with a missed letter. SSA may send you to an exam with their doctor — go, and be on time.

Step 7 — If denied, appeal on time. You generally have 60 days. Many strong cases are approved on appeal — a first denial is not the end.

What You Need — Document Checklist

- ☐ Birth certificate and Social Security card
- ☐ Proof of citizenship or legal status
- ☐ List of all doctors, hospitals, and clinics — with dates of visits
- ☐ Medical records and test results
- ☐ Medication list — name, dose, who prescribed it, and why
- ☐ Work history — jobs from the last 5 years, with duties and dates
- ☐ School records (for a child: IEPs, 504 plans, evaluations, teacher reports)
- ☐ Proof of income and resources (pay stubs, bank statements, tax returns)
- ☐ Names and contact information for people who know about the condition

How Long Does It Take?

A first decision commonly takes about **3 to 6 months**. If the first answer is no, the next step (called reconsideration) can take a few more months. If your case goes to a hearing with a judge, the whole path can take **1 to 2 years**. With SSDI, there is a 5-month wait before payments start. With SSI, payments start from the month after you apply or become eligible. These are common ranges. Every case is different.

My Notes

Want the complete walk-through? The SSA Complete Packages (Child and Adult) pair a full worksheet with 2 guided Zoom sessions where we complete the application together. See southernoakfw.org or email southernoakfw@gmail.com.

Please read: This worksheet is an educational tool only. It is not legal, tax, medical, or financial advice, and Southern Oak Financial & Wellness is not a law firm and does not provide legal representation. Social Security rules change — confirm current details at ssa.gov or with Social Security before you act. There is no guarantee of approval for any benefit: only the Social Security Administration decides claims. Timelines are common ranges, not promises. This worksheet is for your family's personal use only — no refunds.